

Substance Misuse Policy

SECTIONS 1-4: PURPOSE, SCOPE, RESPONSIBILITIES & PREVENTION

1 PURPOSE

To prevent, identify and respond effectively to substance misuse by children and young people in our care to protect their health, safety and development in line with Tusla, HIQA National Standards, Children First and harm reduction principles.

2 SCOPE

- ✓ All children and young people, staff and the service environment
- ✓ Alcohol, drugs, solvents, vaping and prescribed medication misuse
- ✓ Prevention, education, testing (where appropriate), intervention and support
- ✓ On-site, off-site and return from leave

3 RESPONSIBILITIES

- ✓ **Provider & PIC:** Ensure testing kits, training and referral pathways
- ✓ **Care Staff:** Observe, search where authorised, record and report
- ✓ **Key Workers:** Include substance issues in care plans
- ✓ **Healthcare Staff:** Advise on medical response
- ✓ **All Staff:** Promote healthy lifestyles and complete training

4 PREVENTION & EDUCATION

- ✓ Age-appropriate education on risks included in programmes
- ✓ Healthy alternatives and coping skills promoted
- ✓ Clear rules on possession and use
- ✓ Environmental controls (storage, searches)
- ✓ Risk assessments updated for known vulnerabilities

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SECTIONS 5-7: IDENTIFICATION, RESPONSE & SUPPORT

5 IDENTIFICATION

- ✓ Staff trained to recognise signs of use
- ✓ Substance misuse grade at all times of use
- ✓ Staff trained to recognise signs of use
- ✓ Routine screening and return-from-leave checks
- ✓ Young person disclosures encouraged without fear
- ✓ Information from families and agencies welcomed
- ✓ Concerns documented promptly

6 RESPONSE PROCEDURES

- ✓ Immediate safety measures and medical assessment
- ✓ Testing with consent or as per risk assessment
- ✓ Notification to management, parents and placing authority
- ✓ Sanctions balanced with support
- ✓ Incident recorded and reviewed

7 SUPPORT MEASURES

- ✓ Referral to specialist addiction services
- ✓ Harm reduction and relapse prevention planning
- ✓ Therapeutic support and family involvement
- ✓ Positive behaviour reinforcement
- ✓ Impact on placement monitored

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SECTIONS 8-10: COMPLIANCE, MONITORING & POLICY REVIEW

8 COMPLIANCE & TRAINING

- ✓ Staff trained in substance awareness and response
- ✓ Safe storage and disposal of substances
- ✓ GDPR-compliant recording
- ✓ Collaboration with HSE addiction services
- ✓ Immediate action on breaches

9 MONITORING & REVIEW

- ✓ Audits of incidents, testing and plans
- ✓ Feedback from young people and staff
- ✓ Trend analysis
- ✓ Compliance with care plans
- ✓ Supervision discussions

10 POLICY REVIEW

- ✓ Reviewed annually or sooner if required
- ✓ Incorporates audits, feedback and updates
- ✓ Considers emerging substances
- ✓ Reviewed policy approved by Registered Provider and communicated to all staff
- ✓ Superseded versions archived per record management procedures